

SENATE No. 2535

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

SENATE, June 23, 2025.

The committee on Higher Education to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 939) of Joan B. Lovely, Joanne M. Comerford, Michael D. Brady, James B. Eldridge and other members of the General Court for legislation to establish the hunger-free campus initiative that would provide grants to institutions of public higher education to address student food insecurity and hunger, reports the accompanying bill (Senate, No. 2535).

For the committee,
Joanne M. Comerford

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An Act establishing the hunger-free campus initiative.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 Chapter 15A of the General Laws is hereby amended by adding the following section:-

2 Section 48. (a) Subject to appropriation, there shall be a hunger-free campus grant
3 program managed by the department to provide grants to institutions of public higher education
4 to address student food insecurity and hunger. This grant program shall also be available to
5 municipally administered colleges and to minority-serving institutions as defined under 20
6 U.S.C. 1067k (3) as determined by the United States Department of Education. Funding for the
7 grant program may include, but not be limited to, appropriations from the Education and
8 Transportation Fund established in section 2BBBBBB of chapter 29.

9 Using funding allocated under the grant program, the department is authorized to hire a
10 director of the program who shall report to the commissioner. The director shall develop
11 guidelines and procedures governing the grant making process and the program using available
12 data pertaining to student hunger. The director may also conduct any additional surveys the

department deems necessary to understand gaps in addressing student food insecurity and hunger eligible higher education campuses across the commonwealth.

The guidelines and procedures that govern the program shall specify any requirements applicable to eligible institutions of higher education in order to apply and qualify for grants under the program, including, but not limited to: (i) whether the institution has designated campus staff to interface with the department; (ii) the existence and extent of any campus-level hunger awareness programs, including notification to students of their rights to participate in federal and state food assistance programs; (iii) whether the institution has established on-campus meal vendors to accept available federal and state nutrition benefits; (iv) the existence or development of a student meal credit sharing program; (v) income based standards by which grant levels are determined according to the student population at each participating campus; and (vi) any other pertinent criteria as developed by the department. The department shall further develop and deliver technical assistance to assist eligible institutions of higher education to meet the goals of this program.

(b) Subject to appropriation, the department shall award grants to institutions that have met the guidelines and procedures established by the department and have submitted an application to the department for a grant under this program. The department shall prioritize regional equity and equitable distribution among types of institutions of public higher education including the university of Massachusetts segment, the state university segment and the community college segment in its distribution of grants. Upon recommendation by the director of the program, the commissioner or a designee shall determine the amount of each grant which shall be used by the institution to address food insecurity among its students in accordance with the program and shall establish reporting guidelines for grant recipients.

(c) Annually, not later than July 1, the department shall submit a report on the hunger-free campus grant program for the preceding fiscal year to the governor, the clerks of the senate and house of representatives and the joint committee on higher education. The report shall include the number and amounts of grants to eligible institutions well as a comprehensive assessment of the program for the applicable year, including, but not limited to: (i) identifying the institutions participating in the program; (ii) describing the activities supported by awards; (iii) describing the level of student engagement in activities; (iv) describing and analysing the outcomes resulting from activities, including, but not limited to, the impact of the program in reducing the number of students experiencing food insecurity; and (v) recommendations on any changes to the program.

(d) There shall be established and set up on the books of the commonwealth a separate fund to be known as the Hunger-Free Campus Trust Fund administered by the commissioner of higher education. The fund shall be credited with: (i) revenue from appropriations or other money authorized by the general court and specifically designated to be credited to the fund; (ii) interest earned on such revenues; and (iii) funds from public and private sources such as gifts, grants and donations. Amounts credited to the fund shall not be subject to further appropriation and any money remaining in the fund at the end of a fiscal year shall not revert to the General Fund.

(e) Amounts credited to the fund shall be used to fund grants made pursuant to the hunger-free campus grant program, and for the cost of administration of such program by the department of higher education.

(f) Amounts received from private sources shall be approved by the commissioner of higher education and subject to review before being deposited in the fund to ensure that pledged funds are not accompanied by conditions, explicit or implicit, on the implementation of the hunger-free campus grant program that may be detrimental to the program. The review shall be made publicly available.

(g) Annually, not later than October 1, the commissioner shall report to the clerks of the senate and house of representatives, the joint committee on higher education and the house and senate committees on ways and means on the fund's activity including: (i) the source and amount of funds received; (ii) the amounts distributed and the purpose of expenditures from the fund; (iii) any grants provided to institutions of higher education and other stakeholder organizations; and (iv) anticipated revenue and expenditure projections for the next year.